VOL. 1 · NO. 29 PRINTED FOR DANIEL PRICE: ONE CUP OF COFFEE

The Morning Newspaper

THURSDAY, OCTOBER 15, 2026 · AUSTIN EDITION

89° / 72° | Overcast, 2% rain, wind up to 11 mph | Tomorrow: 77° / 52°, drizzle | Sunrise 7:33 · Sunset 19:00 | Waxing crescent

Zelensky Vows to Resume Strikes on Russian Refineries

Kyiv says a US-brokered pause on hitting Russian energy sites is over after fresh Russian attacks, as suspected Russian drones sink or damage a fifth tanker near Romania and Bulgaria and NATO weighs redeploying anti-drone defenses to the Black Sea.

WORLD

School Roof Collapse in Peshawar Kills More Than 30

BBC · NYT

A roof collapsed at a school in Peshawar, Pakistan, killing at least 32 children and a teacher and injuring dozens more, officials said. Rescue crews are still searching the rubble of the building, which a local official said had been dilapidated for years and should have been closed long before the disaster.

TECH

OpenAI Warns Staff of Espionage Risk, Honeypots

TECHMEME · WALL STREET JOURNAL

OpenAI executives have told employees to watch for espionage tactics, including honeypots and insider threats, and to adopt tighter operational security, the Wall Street Journal reports. The warning reflects growing unease in Silicon Valley over foreign intelligence interest in frontier AI labs, where researchers and their model weights are now treated as targets worth protecting like trade secrets.

Supermarket Fridge Hack Sparked Fires, Cost Millions

ARS TECHNICA

A security breach that hit roughly 700 supermarkets and sparked fires traced back to outdated refrigeration units left exposed to the open internet, Ars Technica reports. The resulting damage ran into the millions of dollars, a reminder that aging industrial equipment plugged into the internet for convenience is often never patched.

MARKETS

INDEX	LAST	CHG
S&P 500	7,688.76	-0.39%
Dow Jones	51,742.63	+0.23%
Nasdaq	26,412.64	-1.05%
Russell 2000	2,728.89	-0.02%
VIX	17.70	+4.92%
10-yr yield	5.06	-2.47%
CRYPTO		
Bitcoin	$80,564	-2.76%
Ethereum	$2,349.31	-5.03%
STOCKS		
NVDA	$214.48	-3.08%
AAPL	$346.27	+0.96%
MSFT	$534.66	+0.18%
GOOGL	$348.90	+0.36%
AMZN	$250.39	-1.45%
META	$732.45	-0.69%
AVGO	$337.11	-2.64%
TSLA	$359.30	-2.14%
SPCX	$143.32	-5.81%
BRK-B	$532.49	+1.17%
TSM	$411.52	-4.30%

Chipmakers led the market lower: Nvidia fell 3.1% and Taiwan Semiconductor dropped 4.3%, dragging the Nasdaq down 1.05% even as the Dow eked out a gain on strength in Berkshire Hathaway and Apple. The VIX rose nearly 5% while the 10-year yield slipped, a flight-to-safety pattern as drone and missile attacks on oil tankers in the Gulf and the Black Sea kept energy and shipping jitters elevated. Bitcoin and Ethereum each fell more than 2.5% in sympathy with the risk-off mood in tech. Traders are watching whether the AI-spending trade that has powered chip stocks all year is due for a pause.

ON THIS DAY

In 1997, NASA's Cassini probe launched from Cape Canaveral on a seven-year journey to Saturn, arriving in 2004 to begin thirteen years of orbiting the ringed planet and its moons.

FROM THE FEEDS · FULL TEXT IN SECTION B

ASTRAL CODEX TEN
AI Safety Is Not a Corporate Plot — pushes back on the cynical read that AI-safety work is just a PR shield for labs.

LONGREADS
Deskilling the Body — an essay on how convenience technology is quietly eroding basic bodily skills like sensing and navigating.

LONGREADS
How Tree Rings Challenged the Myth of American Wilderness — dendrochronologists trace fire scars showing Indigenous land management long before colonization.

NAUTILUS
Our Messy Cyborg Past and Future — an interview on the tangled history of mind-control science and fiction.

NAUTILUS
The Death of a Russian Plague Researcher, Explained by a Microbiologist — a scientist sizes up how worried the public should actually be.

QUANTA MAGAZINE
How Do Fungi Keep the Planet Healthy? — fungal networks trade nutrients with plants and help keep carbon underground.

QUANTA MAGAZINE
Triplet of Ghostly Galaxies Hints at What Dark Matter Is — and Isn't — a galactic collision complicates alternative-gravity theories.

TRICYCLE
Transforming Suffering Into a Way of Living — a secular Buddhist author on using art to work through pain.

PSYCHE
How Mental Disorders Play Havoc With Our Motivation — a psychiatrist on why the usual cost-benefit math for getting things done breaks down.

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Sources: RSS, Open-Meteo, Yahoo Finance, CoinGecko, web

ASTRAL CODEX TEN

AI Safety Is Not A Corporate Plot

SCOTT ALEXANDER · ASTRALCODEXTEN.COM · OCT 15, 2026

A sharp rebuttal to the idea that AI-safety work is just cover for corporate interests.

AI companies like Anthropic and OpenAI have long mentioned the possibility that their products could be existentially dangerous, but this has recently crescendoed into even more dire warnings, including suggestions that we have to pace the frontier, ie coordinate to slow AI progress.

In response, cynical commentators have suggested this is a conspiracy to boost the companies' stocks. The exact motives imputed vary from person to person. Some say the companies are hyping the product by talking about how dangerous it is; if AI is smart enough to kill all humans, it must be smart enough for your business workflow. Others say they're trying to distract from near-term harms; every inch of newspaper space devoted to human extinction is one less inch that can be spent on plagiarism and water use. But the most popular story involves regulatory capture: if the product is unsafe, maybe it can only be trusted to a few big politically-connected companies, and everyone else should be banned.

Many debates about AI are complicated and hard to resolve, but this one isn't: all of these stories are clearly false. Some evidence:

- The AI experts who aren't affiliated with big companies are just as concerned as the ones who are.

- The AI company leaders giving these warnings were giving the exact same warnings before they had AI companies - and in many cases, before they worked in the industry, or before the industry existed.

- If these corporate plots were real, they would be incredibly dumb.

Taking these in order:

I. The AI Experts Who Aren't Affiliated With Big Companies Are Just As Concerned As The Ones Who Are

Continued online (full article about 3122 words). Scan, or visit https://www.astralcodexten.com/p/ai-safety-is-not-a-corporate-plot

LONGREADS

Deskilling the Body

CHERI LUCAS ROWLANDS · LONGREADS.COM · OCT 15, 2026

An essay on how convenience technology is eroding basic bodily skills like sensing and navigating.

"We have fallen into habits that are steadily deskilling the human body," writes Melanie Challenger. "This is a strange turn of events for an animal whose success comes mostly from the extraordinary ability to learn through experience." For Aeon, Challenger explores how modern technologies, from GPS to AI, are eroding our body's physical skills by replacing the embodied experiences through which we learn.

After all, the brain is itself a physical organ, continually shaped by what the body does and encounters. Once we decide that the mind is the real human and the rest of the body only hardware, it becomes easier to disregard the physical work, including the neurocognitive work of a biological brain, through which we move, find our way, put thoughts into words, and recognise our own needs. A machine may do some of that work faster, but each act it takes over is one that the body no longer performs and that the body, including the brain, no longer learns through. The irony is that a project motivated by the desire to overcome bodily fragility is helping to produce more fragile bodies.

More writing at Aeon

"When I found the mushroom Amanita muscaria being sold in candy wrappers, I uncovered legal loopholes, dangerous dosages and more."

"The Andoque of the Amazon know what we have forgotten: the forest's most beautiful creatures are also its most dangerous."

"Tech titans claim the genre inspired them. But all they've done is graft their politics onto stories of a better future."

LONGREADS

How Tree Rings Challenged the Myth of American Wilderness

SEYWARD DARBY · LONGREADS.COM · OCT 15, 2026

Dendrochronologists trace fire scars showing Indigenous land management long before colonization.

By studying fire scars in ancient wood, many scientists have become convinced that Indigenous people transformed North America long before European colonizers arrived. M.R. O'Connor spends time with dendrochronologists, who study tree rings, and other experts to understand what they're learning:

Anthropologist Omer Stewart, who began documenting Native American burning practices in the nineteen-thirties . . . found that Indigenous communities burned prairies to attract bison to fresh grass and to maintain oak "orchards" where food could be gathered. He became convinced that Native Americans had reshaped the geography, and in some cases the climate, of North American ecosystems. Their impact "was profound, in terms of the amount of land converted to agriculture, the species they hunted and fished, and most particularluthe way they shaped their world through the use of fire," the naturalist Scott Weidensaul wrote, in his 2012 book The First Frontier. Weidensaul argued that early America "was fruitful beyond modern recognition, it was riotous in its natural wealth, but it was not wilderness." The dendrochronologist Evan Larson, at the University of Wisconsin-Platteville, made a similar claim: settlers encountered rich landscapes because Native Americans were tending them. "Whenever you're talking about fire, you're engaging with a central narrative around this untamed frontier and wilderness," Larson told me. "In fact, that's never been true. The early success of pioneers was already benefitting from the labor of somebody else."

LONGREADS

Beyond the Glass

DANIEL BARNUM · LONGREADS.COM · OCT 15, 2026

A grieving son finds his way through a museum collection of skulls.

Daniel Barnum | Longreads | October 15, 2026 | 4,116 words (15 minutes)

The Hyrtl Skull Collection is the first exhibit you notice when you walk into the Mütter Museum at the College of Physicians of Philadelphia. This is by curatorial design: The skulls face the main entrance, staring steadily at each person who crosses the threshold. All 139 are evenly spaced in long lines behind the glass doors of a towering cherrywood cabinet. Each one rests in a wire frame on top of a thin balsa box with a tag at its center. I recall tracking them with glances as I shuffled nearby with two friends, as part of a large crowd. Small bright lights illuminated them from inside the cases, making them glow dully from my angle. Seeing them for the first time, I was both mesmerized by this effect and intimidated by the skulls' great number. I tried not to look for too long, but the density of people on the narrow walkway made that impossible: I was soon stuck in the dead center of the exhibit. Almost in spite of myself, I scanned the wall text and learned how they had been brought together to disprove a piece of 19th-century race science, which seemed like one of the better reasons to collect skulls.

Most of the exhibits in the Mütter Museum have similarly odd origins. Tucked into a corner of the College of Physicians' stately New Beaux-Arts building, the Mütter is a 19th-century medical teaching collection/cabinet museum with an annual visitorship of almost 150,000 people. Its staff goes on late-night talk shows with specimens in tow, hosts YouTube series. The gift shop sells soaps and keychains in the shapes of its artifacts.

Continued online (full article about 4189 words). Scan, or visit https://longreads.com/2026/10/15/mother-museum-skulls-grief-agni/